

Project Browse — design foundation, pre-PRD summary

3 July 2026 · Consolidates the design brief, decisions taken during design, and the modelled surfaces. Input to the PRD.

1. What this is

A macOS desktop browser (Electron shell) that quietly learns how its owner works and, sparingly, offers to fold what it notices back into the interface — chiefly as workspaces. It is not a Chrome clone with a sidebar: the ambition is to exceed the caliber of Arc and Zen, built for someone who lives in web apps and modern SaaS tools. Light and dark mode from day one.

2. Product thesis

"A browser that quietly adapts, without asking you to learn a new way of browsing." Design carries most of that sentence:

- The intelligence must feel like the user's own reflection — "my data, shown to me" — never "something has been watching me". The two are separated by copy and restraint, not features.
- Calm is the aesthetic position: quiet, typographic, almost boring, so the moments of recognition carry the emotional weight.
- The first hour must feel like a good, modern browser with no manual required — while being unapologetically its own tool (sidebar-first, keyboard-first), not a Chrome imitation.

3. Non-negotiable constraints

1. Never more than two suggestions visible anywhere, ever.
2. No dashboards. Home never becomes a widget grid; no day-one configuration begging.
3. No editorialising. Banned: productivity scores, streaks, comparisons, saved-hours claims, red/amber/green on behaviour, gamification.
4. Aggressive rounding — "about a dozen mornings", never "13 times at 08:47". False precision reads as surveillance.
5. Every learned element explainable in one tap: "Why am I seeing this?" is a first-class affordance.
6. Everything observed stays on the machine; the Learning page is the complete, honest ledger of it.

4. Decisions taken during design

Decision	Outcome
Shell layout	Sidebar-first. Left rail: workspace switcher → ⌘K entry → promoted Applications grid → vertical tabs → dormant workspaces and Downloads at the foot. The page is the stage; no persistent URL bar — a quiet domain readout in the page header.
Type	Single voice ("1c"): Instrument Sans throughout — chrome and learned surfaces share one register, differentiated by surface (a faint teal wash), not typeface.
Accent	Still-water teal, oklch(0.54 0.08 195) light / oklch(0.72 0.08 195) dark. Jobs: focus rings, active workspace dot, the confirm action, the noticed-card wash. Nothing decorative.
Palette	Warm-neutral paper (#FBFAF8 canvas, #F3F1EC wells) with ink text (#21201C); chroma near zero except the accent. Dark mode mirrors it in tokens.css.
Name	"Workspace" was a placeholder. Recommended: Sill (the quiet ledge of a window). Alternates: Margin, Alcove, Commonplace. Not yet ratified.
Icon direction	A windowsill: one teal ledge low in the frame on warm paper; a resting dot appears at 48px+. Reads at 16px; no orbs or gradients.
Fidelity	Static hi-fi, light mode first. Dark mode values exist in tokens; dark comps not yet produced.

5. Surfaces modelled (and where they live)

Each is a hi-fi HTML prototype in this project; tokens.css is the build contract (names stable, values may change).

- **Shell chrome** (Shell Chrome v2) — default shell, workspace-switcher popover, and the restore transition: rail rebuilds instantly with skeletons of the actual returning tabs ("Research, as you left it — 12 tabs"), never a lone spinner. Dormant workspaces are faint facts, not alerts.
- **Home in three temporal states** (Home) — day one: greeting, search, recent, one import invitation. Week one: discovered Applications appear. Month one: at most two "noticed" cards join. One evolving system, not features unlocking. Also holds the import-consent screen (under 60 words, "Not now" keeps observation off, browser fully works either way) and the interim state ("Watching quietly. Patterns usually appear within a few days.").
- **The suggestion card** (Suggestion Card) — anatomy: plain-language observation, rounded evidence line, inline "Why?"; exactly two actions (a question to confirm; Dismiss). Confirm flow: card becomes the naming form in place (no modal) → the payoff, a workspace born pre-populated with its sites — quietly

momentous, no confetti. Dismissal: 120 ms fade, "Okay. That one won't come back.", undo lives only on the Learning page.

- **The Learning page** (Learning Page) — the trust ledger: aggregate observations, patterns noticed (each with "forget"), suggestions made and their outcomes, the never-observed list (private windows, banking/health by category, user-added sites leaving no trace at all). Pause and delete—everything visible without scrolling; paused state carries no guilt; delete confirm is sober and specific (workspaces survive, learning doesn't).
- **Command palette** (Command Palette) — conventional ⌘K, calm appearance; groups: actions, workspaces, applications, history, web search fallback. No learning behaviour in the PoC.
- **Voice & copy rules** (Voice and Copy.md) — the register codified: observation as subject, past-tense rounded evidence, zero exclamation marks or emoji, never "for you", never imperative — "Want this as a workspace?" is the shape. Ten worked card copies plus three counter-examples.
- **Identity** (Identity) — name treatment, icon direction, accent decision as above.

6. Explicitly out of scope

Settings beyond the exclusion list; capability panels, marketplaces, SDKs; notification surfaces; automation builders; Windows/Linux chrome; onboarding beyond the single import-consent screen.

7. Open questions for the PRD

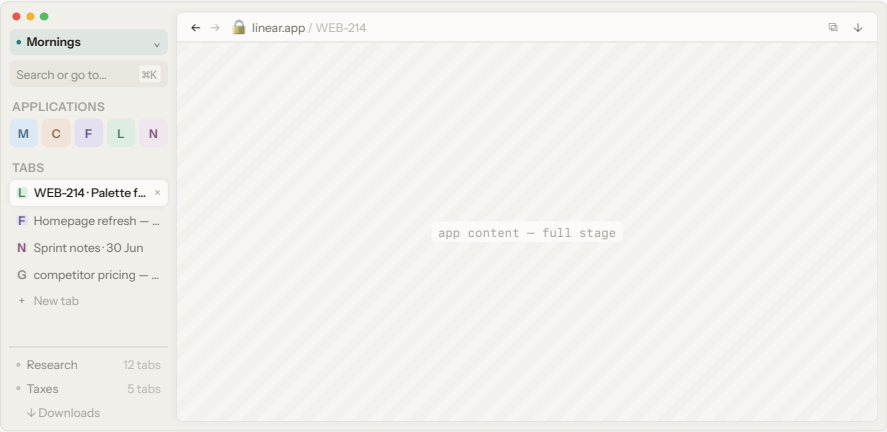
1. Ratify the name (Sill recommended) — it gates the icon, wordmark, and consent-screen copy.
2. Dark mode comps: token values exist; the surfaces need a dark pass before build M5 signs off both modes.
3. Interaction fidelity: everything so far is static by choice. Which flows need working prototypes for validation — switcher transition, confirm flow, ⌘K?
4. The "Everything else" default workspace (where unclaimed tabs live once a first workspace is born) is implied by the payoff screen and needs a defined behaviour.
5. Suggestion cadence and decay: how long a card may sit unanswered on Home, and whether it quietly withdraws.
6. Whether the two-suggestion cap is global (Home + anywhere) or per surface — the design assumes global.

8. The test every screen must pass

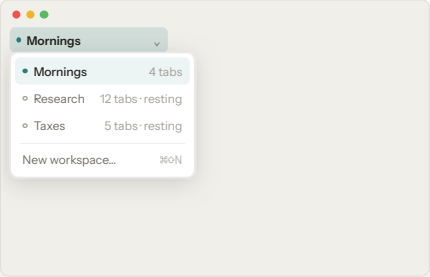
Two questions: would someone new to it understand this without explanation — if no, simplify. Does the observation feel like the user's own reflection — if no, quieten it.

Shell chrome (D2a)

D2a v2 · sidebar-first shell for people who live in web apps. Rail: workspace → command → Applications → tabs. The page is the stage; chrome recedes.



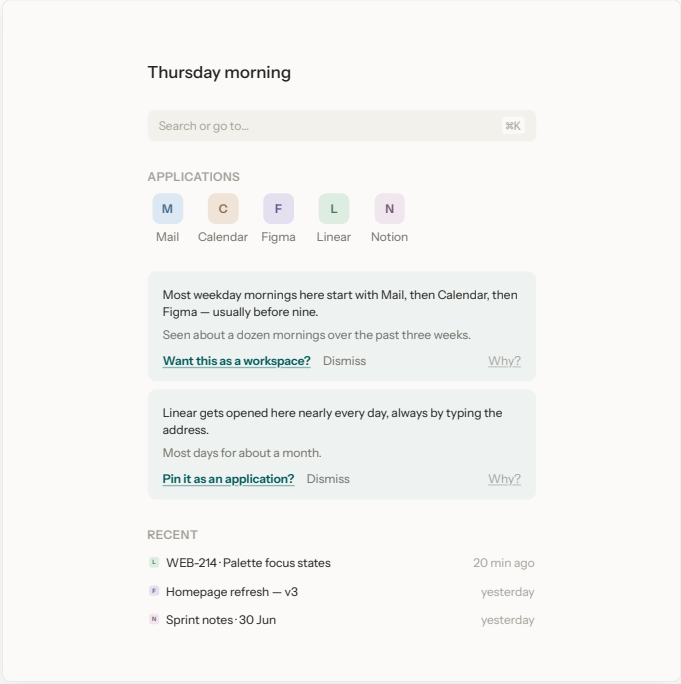
D2a v2 · switcher - one action to change context. Dormant workspaces are plain facts in faint ink; no badges, no urgency.



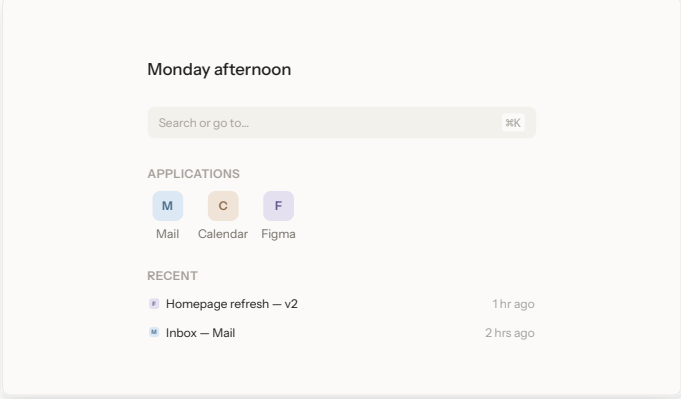
D2a v2 · switching to Research, ~0-2s - the rail rebuilds instantly with skeletons of the actual returning tabs. Context preserved, never a lone spinner.



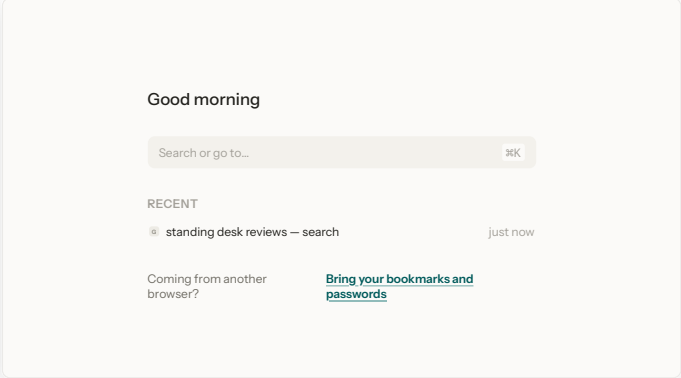
D2b · month one — at most two noticed cards join, below the fold of attention. Same page, grown; nothing unlocked.



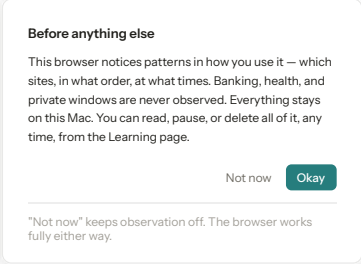
D2b · week one — discovered Applications appear. Icon + name, restrained; no cards yet.



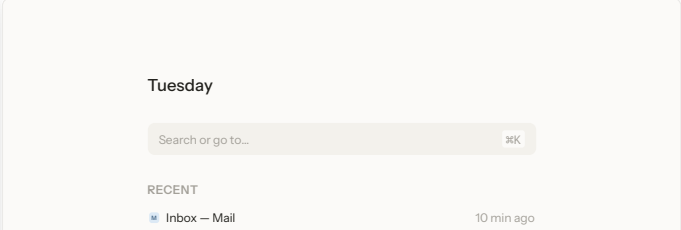
D2b · day one — search, recent pages, an import invitation. Nothing else. No widget grid, no configuration begging.



D2f · the single import-consent screen — what is observed, what is excluded, where data lives. Under 60 words.



D2f · post-import, pre-detection — honest, unanxious, no progress bars pretending to know. Lives as one quiet line on Home.



Watching quietly. Patterns usually appear within a few days.

The suggestion card & confirm flow (D2c)

D2c · anatomy — observation, evidence, why, exactly two actions. Direction 1c: one voice, a wash not a box.

Most weekday mornings here start with Mail, then Calendar, then Figma — usually before nine.

Seen about a dozen mornings over the past three weeks. Setting it up by hand takes a couple of minutes each time.

[Want this as a workspace?](#) [Dismiss](#) [Why?](#)

Observation — plain language, first person of the data, present tense. 16px, full ink.

Evidence — past tense, aggressively rounded. "About a dozen", never "13 times at 08:47".

Two actions, exactly — confirm is a question, dismiss is one word. No third option, no "later".

Why? — always present, visually last, never buried.

D2c · "Why am I seeing this?" — one tap, inline, no modal. Answers with the same facts the Learning page holds.

Most weekday mornings here start with Mail, then Calendar, then Figma — usually before nine.

Seen about a dozen mornings over the past three weeks.

This comes from the order sites were opened on weekday mornings — nothing about what was on them. It's recorded on this Mac and listed on the Learning page. Dismissing this suggestion also forgets the pattern.

[See it on the Learning page](#)

[Want this as a workspace?](#) [Dismiss](#)

D2c · confirm, step 1 — the card itself becomes the naming form. No modal, no wizard. One suggested name, editable.

Mail, Calendar and Figma — weekday mornings.

Call it

Back [Make the workspace](#)

D2c · the payoff — the workspace exists, pre-populated with its sites. Quietly momentous: a settled room, not confetti. Full shell so the moment lands in context.

• Mornings

Search or go to... ⌘K

TABS

M Inbox — Mail

C Calendar — Week

F Homepage refresh — Figma

◦ Everything else 9 tabs

•

Mornings

Mail, Calendar and Figma are here. Tomorrow morning this is one click.

It keeps itself tidy — nothing to maintain.

D2c · dismissal — immediate, undramatic, gone. 120ms fade, the page closes the gap. One quiet line, then nothing. No undo toast demanding attention; undo lives on the Learning page.

Okay. That one won't come back.

The card fades in 120ms and the layout closes. The line above shows for a few seconds where the card was, then the page is exactly as if the suggestion never existed. The dismissed pattern is recorded — and reversible — on the Learning page only.

D2d · the trust ledger – your own well-kept notebook, not an admin panel. Pause and delete-all visible without scrolling.

Learning

Observing locally since 14 June. Nothing has left this machine.

Pause observation

Delete everything

OBSERVED, IN AGGREGATE

Site visits and their order, on about forty sites. Times of day, rounded to the hour. Which sites get opened together. Nothing about page content, and nothing from the excluded list below.

NOTICED SO FAR

A weekday-morning routine – Mail, Calendar, Figma

since mid-June

forget

Linear opened most days, always by typed address

since early June

forget

A Sunday-evening pattern around meal-planning sites

recent, still settling

forget

SUGGESTIONS MADE

The morning routine, as a workspace

accepted – became "Mornings"

A news-reading pattern over lunch

dismissed 26 June

undo

NEVER OBSERVED

Private windows. Banking and health sites, by category. And anything you add:

monzo.com

nhs.uk

therapyroute.com

+ add a site

Excluded sites leave no trace here at all – not even a count.

D2d · paused – plain statement of fact, no guilt, no nagging to resume.

Learning

Paused since 2 July. What was learned before is kept below, untouched, until you say otherwise.

Resume observation

Delete everything

D2d · delete everything – sober, specific, honoured immediately. No "are you sure?!" theatre, but the consequence is stated exactly.

Delete everything learned?

Every observation, pattern and suggestion record is erased from this Mac. Workspaces you created stay. This can't be undone.

Keep it

Delete

Command palette (D2e)

D2e · ⌘K with a query – conventional interaction, calm appearance. Groups: actions, workspaces, applications, history. No learning behaviour in the PoC.

mor|

esc

WORKSPACES

• Mornings

switch ↵

HISTORY

G mortgage overpayment calculator

last week

N Team offsite – Morocco notes

June

SEARCH

◦ Search the web for "mor"

↑↓ move ⌘↵ open ⌘↵ new tab

D2e · ⌘K, nothing typed – actions and places, ready. Feels inevitable, not clever.

Search, go to, or do...

esc

ACTIONS

+ New tab

⌘T

▢ New workspace

⌘oN

WORKSPACES

• Mornings

current

◦ Research

APPLICATIONS

M Mail

L Linear

↑↓ move ⌘↵ open ⌘↵ new tab

D4 · name treatment — recommended: Sill. Short, domestic, zero tech-brand residue. Wordmark is just the UI face, medium weight, tightly set. Alternates shown small.

Sill

The quiet ledge of a window — where things sit and are noticed without being handled. No tagline in-product. Where one is unavoidable (the website), it is a sentence in the product's own voice: "A browser that notices."

Margin
alternate

Alcove
alternate

Commonplace
alternate

D4 · icon direction — a windowsill: one horizontal ledge, low in the frame, teal on warm paper. Reads at 16px, belongs in a macOS dock, no gradient mesh, no orb.



128px · dock



48px



16px

The ledge carries the mark alone at small sizes. The dot — something resting on the sill — appears only at 48px and above. The one accent, nothing else; dark mode inverts the paper, the ledge stays teal.

D4 · the single accent — still-water teal, already in tokens.css. Its whole job list, in full.



light



dark



quiet

Used for: focus rings, the active workspace dot, the confirm action, and the wash behind noticed cards. Used for nothing decorative — no headers, no illustrations, no charts. If a screen has more than two teal elements, something is wrong.

The register for every learned surface. One page; if a line can't be checked against this, don't ship it.

The rules

1. **First person singular of the data, not the system.** "Most mornings here start with Mail" — the subject is the pattern, never "I recommend" or "We noticed you". "I noticed..." is acceptable only as the register's name; on screen, prefer sentences where the observation itself is the subject.
2. **Evidence is past tense and aggressively rounded.** "Seen about a dozen mornings over the past three weeks." Never counts with false precision, never timestamps.
3. **Zero exclamation marks. Zero emoji.** Everywhere, forever.
4. **No anthropomorphic enthusiasm.** The browser is not proud of you, excited for you, or cheering you on.
5. **Never "for you".** "A workspace with these sites" — not "a workspace made just for you".
6. **Never imperative.** "Create a workspace!" is banned. The shape is a question: "Want this as a workspace?"
7. **Describe, never judge.** No productivity scores, streaks, comparisons, saved-hours claims, or health colours on behaviour.
8. **Dismissal is honoured in words too.** "Okay. That one won't come back." Nothing that pleads or renegotiates.
9. **Facts about privacy are stated plainly, in full sentences.** "Nothing has left this machine." Not badges, not shield icons.
10. **Every learned line must answer "why am I seeing this?" in one tap,** in the same voice, with the same facts the Learning page holds.

Ten worked card copies

Sequence routines

1. *Observation:* Most weekday mornings here start with Mail, then Calendar, then Figma — usually before nine.
Evidence: Seen about a dozen mornings over the past three weeks.
Action: Want this as a workspace?
2. *Observation:* Sunday evenings tend to end on recipe sites, and Monday's shopping order follows.
Evidence: Most Sundays for about two months.
Action: Want this as a workspace?
3. *Observation:* When Linear is open, GitHub and the staging site are usually open with it.
Evidence: Together on most working days.
Action: Want these grouped as a workspace?

Rituals

1. *Observation:* The last hour of most Fridays here is spent on expense and timesheet pages.
Evidence: About three Fridays a month.
Action: Want this as a workspace?
2. *Observation:* Around lunch, the same three news sites come up, then close within the half hour.
Evidence: Most weekdays this month.
Action: Want this as a workspace?
3. *Observation:* Trips start here with the same pair: the airline account and the calendar.
Evidence: Each of the last four bookings.
Action: Want this as a workspace?

Application promotion

1. *Observation:* Linear gets opened here nearly every day, always by typing the address.
Evidence: Most days for about a month.
Action: Pin it as an application?
2. *Observation:* Figma is usually the first tab of the day and the last one closed.
Evidence: Most working days since mid-June.
Action: Pin it as an application?
3. *Observation:* This webmail is where about half of all time here goes.
Evidence: Consistently, over the past month.
Action: Pin it as an application?
4. *Observation:* The same internal dashboard gets retyped from memory a few times a week.
Evidence: Regularly since early June.
Action: Pin it as an application?

Three examples of what not to write

1. **"You're on a 5-day streak of morning productivity! 🔥 Create your Morning Power workspace!"**
Streak (gamification), judgement ("productivity"), emoji, exclamation marks, imperative, anthropomorphic excitement. Every rule at once.
2. **"We noticed you opened Mail at 08:47 on 13 occasions. To save 22.4 minutes per week, we recommend a workspace."**
"We" makes it the system watching. False precision reads as surveillance. Saved-time claims are editorialising. The confirm is a recommendation, not a question.
3. **"Create a workspace for you?"**
Closest miss of the three — it's short and a question. But "for you" positions the browser as a benefactor, and "Create" leads with the system's action rather than the user's pattern. The shape is: pattern first, then "Want this as a workspace?"